

Grounded At Sea



Which is the oldest trophy in sport? Football's FA Cup, of course. Which is the most expensive sport in the world? Formula One, but naturally. In which sport do big money, big egos and big mouths collide in a constant clamour? Heavy-weight boxing, without a doubt. Wrong every time.

It is yachting's America's Cup, which began in 1851, 20 years before the FA Cup. It is still going even though no one but the Americans won for 132 years. Right now it is being sailed off the coast of Spain between a yacht from New Zealand, a country of naturally nautical islanders, and another from Switzerland, a country surrounded by land on all sides.

Among those who have actually raced in this ultra-prestigious event are media magnate Ted Turner and software tycoon Larry Ellison. The leader of the champion Swiss team is a biotech billionaire named Ernesto Bertarelli. The collective budget for teams competing in the America's Cup crosses \$500 million without sneezing.

The Cup could have turned into an event meant only for the monstrously rich and the chronically famous. For mad billionaires willing to gamble away their moolah for extra cred at the home yacht club. In any case, the sport is also extremely spectator and TV-unfriendly. But still the lure of America's Cup is growing. Olympic medalists vie to make it to competing syndicates even though one NBA player's salary can pay for an entire Cup team. Boats are covered with the logos of big-ticket sponsors and mounted with cameras and mikes that fill TV screen with sea spray and the swearing of sailors.

The challenger races for the right to meet defending Swiss yacht *Alinghi* included first-time teams from South Africa and China. The New Zealand Government has put in \$26 million in the 2007 challenge, after Bertarelli signed up leading Kiwi yachtsmen and went on to win the Cup for the Swiss in 2003. The venue for the Cup defence was open to bidding, and already the turnstiles at the racing dock in Valencia, Spain, have registered five million entries. The port city has been revitalised. Bertarelli, despised by many for competing with his cheque book, says he wants to make the Cup self-sustaining and not dependant on the deep pockets of a few.

Everyone opposing Formula One in India should take a cue from what is happening out at sea in Spain. Behind every extravagant sporting event, lies an opportunity.



SAURABH SINGH

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"Politics does not suit me"

BOLLYWOOD ACTOR DHARMENDRA SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about his return to acting and his new film

Q. You have completed 50 years in Bollywood. How old are you?

A. I'm 18. My life has just begun. I did a very good role in *Metro*. Now my sons want to make a film for me.

Q. You got the IIFA Life Achievement award.

A. It was for my contribution to the film industry. If my new film does well, it'll be a new beginning for me.

Q. Is it difficult to maintain friends in Bollywood?

A. Relations are sweet if you know how to maintain them; you can't live without these relations. I give love to people and get love from them.

Q. How do you differentiate between your friends and enemies?

A. I always try to turn enemies into friends with love.

Q. Your new film *Apne* is based on a father's unfulfilled dream. Is it your life story?

A. I am working with Sunny and Bobby. The script is very good and the screenplay is very touching. It is an emotional film in which I aspire to be a heavyweight champion but due to doping charges I fail.

Q. You were close to Meena Kumari.

A. She was a great artist and I was her fan.

Q. How did you decide your son's roles in *Apne*?

A. Sunny plays an introvert. The film is complete now and my dream has come true.

Q. You don't give much importance to your daughters.

A. This is not true. It's good if my daughters do not attend *filmi* functions.

Our family is very conventional. I never wanted Isha to do films. But now I'm searching for a good story for her. She is my darling.

Q. In politics, some people are not with you.

A. They're all with me. Even Congress workers cooperate with me.

Q. What are your future plans?

A. Films are my first love, my life and soul. I never wanted to go away from the film industry. But I couldn't face the camera due to a certain situation.

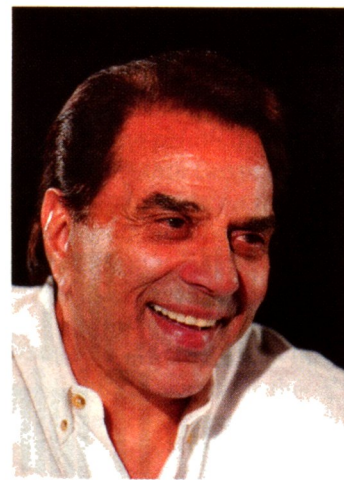
Q. Your attendance is very poor in Parliament. Will you contest elections again?

A. Politics doesn't suit me. It all depends on destiny.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>



BHASKAR PAUL